Things to Notice and Note Now That Mom Has Medicaid

Changes in her money, her care and her mail: fifteen everyday things to write down, with no interpreting.

Mom's Medicaid is in place and life keeps moving: a different room, a small check from an old policy, a letter in an envelope you don't recognize. This guide names fifteen everyday things worth noticing now and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. Whether a change has to be reported, and what it means for Mom's Medicaid, are questions for the Medicaid agency, your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney, and a dated note is what makes that conversation short. The areas follow the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own list of things to keep an eye on after approval. Justice in Aging notes, in general, that changes in a person's life such as moving or a rise in income can change Medicaid eligibility; whether a particular change matters for Mom isn't for a family to judge. The points about mail and contact information follow the federal renewal flyer and Justice in Aging, and the record-keeping habits follow the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. The wording about what to write down is ours.

The mail and the phone

1 Envelopes from the Medicaid agency [1]

NOTICE Who sent it, the date on the letter, any date it mentions, and whether it asks for anything.

WRITE DOWN The sender, the letter's date, what it asks for in its own words, and where you filed it. Keep the envelope with the letter.

2 Renewal forms and requests for information [1]

NOTICE A form to fill out, a list of documents to send, or a letter saying nothing more is needed.

WRITE DOWN What arrived and when, what you sent back, and the date you sent it. Keep a copy of everything that leaves the house.

3 Mail that turns up somewhere else [1 4]

NOTICE Letters about Mom arriving at her old address, at the facility or at a brother's or sister's house, and any address or phone number the agency has that is out of date.

WRITE DOWN Every place her Medicaid mail arrives, who collects it, and the address and phone number the agency has on file. If one is out of date, the agency is who to tell.

4 Words, dates and amounts you can't explain

NOTICE A term, a date or an amount in a letter that nobody in the family can explain, such as an effective date or a renewal date.

WRITE DOWN The exact wording, which letter it is in, and the question you'd ask about it.

5 Phone calls and conversations

NOTICE A call with the Medicaid agency, the facility's business office or a professional, and anything you were told to do or send.

WRITE DOWN The date, the name of the person, what was said, and what happens next.

Money coming in

6 Her regular income [2]

NOTICE The deposits that arrive each month, such as Social Security or a pension, and any letter saying one is going up, going down, starting or stopping.

WRITE DOWN The source, what changed, the date, and where the letter is.

7 Money nobody expected [3]

NOTICE An inheritance, a gift, a refund, an insurance payment, a check from an old policy or account.

WRITE DOWN What it is, who it came from, the date and where it is now, as plain facts. What happens with it is a question for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

Accounts and property

8 Account statements [3]

NOTICE Each statement as it arrives: the balance at the end of the month, and anything on it you don't recognize.

WRITE DOWN The date, the balance, and any line you have a question about. Keep the statements together.

9 What is paid out for her [3]

NOTICE Payments from Mom's accounts: to the facility or care provider, the pharmacy, an insurance premium, something bought for her.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount, who was paid and what it was for. Keep the receipt, even a small one.

10 Sales, gifts and changes of name

NOTICE Anything of Mom's that is sold, given away, cashed in or put into someone else's name, such as a house, a car or an insurance policy, and any talk in the family of doing so.

WRITE DOWN What happened or what is being considered, the date, and who is involved. What it means, if anything, is a question for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

Where Mom lives and her care

11 A move [2]

NOTICE A different room or unit, a different facility, a hospital stay, a move home or to a relative's house.

WRITE DOWN Where she was, where she is now, the dates, and who told you.

12 Changes in her care

NOTICE A therapy starting or stopping, a change in the kind of care she gets, a new provider, a care meeting on the calendar.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and who told you.

13 Statements from the facility or care provider

NOTICE The period each statement covers, what it says Mom owes, and anything new since the last one.

WRITE DOWN The date, what it asks for, what was paid and from which account. If it doesn't match what a Medicaid letter says, write down both and ask.

Family and legal papers

14 Changes in the family

NOTICE A change in Mom's marital status or in her spouse's situation, or a change in who handles her mail and her money.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and who in the family knows.

15 Legal and financial papers [5]

NOTICE A bank or an agency asking who may act for Mom, a power of attorney being used or questioned, a paper nobody can find.

WRITE DOWN Which paper, the date on it, who asked, and where the original is kept. What a paper allows is a question for an elder law attorney.

When a note isn't enough

A few things on this list are a conversation as well as a note. A letter that asks for something goes to the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner; the federal renewal flyer says to send what a letter asks for as soon as possible. Money that has arrived, or any thought of giving, selling or moving money or property, goes to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anything is done; the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. A letter that says Mom's coverage is changing goes to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney, with its envelope. A change in how Mom herself is doing goes to her nurse or her doctor.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether any of these has to be reported, what any of them means for Mom's Medicaid, or how your family is doing. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. The agency and the professionals do the interpreting, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to notice, and you've started writing it down without having to decide what any of it means. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation, so your notes have somewhere to go, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
2. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
4. Justice in Aging, Unwinding Medicaid Continuous Coverage Protections: Implications and Advocacy for Individuals Dually Eligible for Medicare and Medicaid
5. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness

From the Medicaid Planning Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.